



POWER THROUGH THE STORMS

Affordable, Resilient Energy & Stormwater Infrastructure

Featured Panel Summary | Westchester Clean Energy Action Conference

This featured panel brought together two sitting mayors, a former mayor now working in infrastructure finance, and the state's clean energy siting team to look at storm resilience and energy resilience as one problem rather than two. The conversation moved from post-Sandy planning in Hoboken and watershed-scale stormwater work in New Rochelle, to a train station solar carport in Croton-on-Hudson that turned a budget crisis into revenue, to how NYSERDA helps communities work through siting fights. The through line: the same municipal land, the same capital plans, and the same public conversations decide both whether a community floods and whether it keeps the lights on.

SESSION PANELISTS

Moderator

Frank D'Eufemia, PE
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Yadira Ramos-Herbert Mayor
City of New Rochelle

Ravi Bhalla Dundon Advisers
Former Mayor, City of Hoboken

Weronika Ciechowska Polanco
Clean Energy Siting, NYSERDA

Brian Pugh Mayor
Village of Croton-on-Hudson

1. GET OFF THE LIST: PLAN FIRST, THEN BUILD

Ravi Bhalla described Hoboken as a one square mile city of 65,000 people, the fourth most densely populated in the country, with roughly 75 percent of its landmass below sea level on what used to be marsh and infill. Hurricane Sandy was the wake-up call: about 500 million gallons breached the Hudson from the north and south, filling the city like a bathtub and flooding around 80 percent of it, hitting housing authority residents in the low-lying western portion hardest. A Wall Street Journal list of the top ten cities that will be underwater in fifty years included Hoboken. In 2019 the city adopted one of New Jersey's first climate action plans, a climate master plan that named its two problems, coastal surge and chronic flooding, set mitigation targets against the Paris Agreement, and laid out the adaptation strategy. Hoboken has since moved from planning into implementation, with Rebuild by Design underway, four resiliency parks built, and a fifth in design.

"The reason why we need to take action is because we want to get off the list."

Ravi Bhalla, Dundon Advisers; former Mayor of Hoboken

2. NEW ROCHELLE: WOVEN INTO THE BUILDINGS, FUNDED BY THE GROWTH

New Rochelle Mayor Yadira Ramos-Herbert described a city that has authorized 32 buildings and 11,000 units downtown. The city used that construction wave to embed LEED-certified, forward-thinking standards into what gets constructed, so the city is building for the future rather than for now. She was candid that this did not start as an environmental agenda. What she noticed as a resident and then as an elected official was that every time it rained, the anxiety grew, and it showed up in home values, health, and household finances. Rather than responding hotspot by hotspot, New Rochelle analyzed all six of its watersheds about four years ago to understand how water actually moves through the city, and the success of its development program generated enough resources to set aside \$10 million a year for ten years to act on what the engineering found. That comprehensive stormwater mitigation plan runs in parallel with Green NR and a climate vulnerability assessment which will shape where the city places resiliency hubs.

"I can't say I thought of myself running as a green champion. But as mayor, you're responsive to the concerns of your constituents."

Yadira Ramos-Herbert, Mayor of New Rochelle

3. CROTON-ON-HUDSON AND THE UPSIDE OF THE TRANSITION

Mayor Brian Pugh made the case that a village without an acute flooding crisis still gets to plan, and that the clean energy transition is worth pursuing for its upside rather than only as a defense. Croton-on-Hudson's one true stormwater crisis came with Irene and Sandy, when the Department of Public Works sat in a flood plain at the foot of the train station parking lot, which he called the worst possible arrangement: the department had to clean up after being the one most exposed to a storm. Moving the DPW out of the flood zone took years and finished just in time for the pandemic, which cratered commuting and with it the train station parking revenue that is a significant share of the village budget. That budget pressure is what finally assembled a carport solar array at the parking lot, an idea that had been sitting in planning documents for twenty years or more. Six years after the project began in 2020, it returns over \$400,000 a year to the village. With a total tax levy of about \$13 million, the increased revenue is enough to matter and helps the village stay under the property tax cap.

"Not just the downsides of climate change, which are very serious, but the upsides of the clean energy transition and how communities can benefit from it."

Brian Pugh, Mayor of Croton-on-Hudson

4. THE STATE AS EDUCATOR AND ENABLER

Weronika Ciechowska Polanco explained that NYSEDA's Clean Energy Siting team exists to make the connection between developers, utilities, and local governments, and that the work is mostly face to face: town hall meetings, sessions with first responders, conversations with individual municipal departments and with residents. Every town is a different mix. In one town she visited recently the municipality wanted a battery energy storage project and so did the community, but the fire department was opposed; in the next town the alignment is different again. Her team tracks how moratoriums evolve and works to reduce them by helping communities get comfortable, while being explicit that some communities will not get comfortable right now and that this is a legitimate outcome, because in New York the decision belongs to the local government. She noted that the siting team is one part of a much larger NYSEDA portfolio of incentives and programs, and invited attendees to find her afterward.

"We're educators. We feel like we're the enablers, hopefully."

5. WHEN CLEAN ENERGY SOLVES THE OTHER PROBLEM FIRST

The most transferable idea of the session was that clean energy projects move fastest when they are answering a problem the community already has. Ciechowska Polanco recounted a town supervisor describing a church that was struggling financially but held a large parking lot; a developer offered a battery energy storage project with a financial incentive that would let the congregation continue its programs and rebuild, and the community, which wanted to keep the church, agreed. Her second example ran directly through stormwater. A parcel that flooded constantly was well zoned for battery storage, but residents objected precisely because batteries and standing water do not mix. The developer's answer was to have the project eliminate the flooding issue. The lesson is that these projects can carry multiple potential benefits for communities if they embrace the opportunity.

"We're going to provide you a state-of-the-art water management system that is going to fix this land, and you're not going to have mosquito infestations every summer anymore."

A developer's pitch, as recounted by Weronika Ciechowska Polanco, NYSERDA

6. THE CAPACITY CRUNCH AND THE MUNICIPAL LANDOWNER

Frank D'Eufemia framed the second half around load growth: electrification, artificial intelligence, advanced manufacturing, and local density have led the New York Independent System Operator to warn that even with the renewable investment driven by the CLCPA, the Lower Hudson Valley, New York City, and Long Island face a megawatt deficiency at summer peak beginning in 2026. Pugh's response was that local governments are significant land holders and siting is always a challenge, so municipal property is a way to be part of the solution and benefit from it. Croton's train station solar and battery storage array is privately owned and structured as a community array, with individual subscribers and Columbia University as the anchor customer. A second carport array at the relocated DPW will be village-owned. The village's first municipal array, at a fire station, was overseen by former mayor Leo Wiegman, now director of solar programs at Sustainable Westchester. Mayor Ramos-Herbert reported a grant of just under \$1 million to put solar on the top floor of the New Rochelle train station, the second busiest on the New Haven Line, with the goal of making the facility net zero. Bhalla noted that New Jersey sits on the PJM grid, a thirteen-state consortium under the same AI data center strain, and described two Hoboken responses: buying solar from a farm to create a community solar program for housing authority residents who have no roof of their own, with the savings reinvested in capital improvements, and a community energy aggregation program that made renewable supply the default and required residents to opt out. He added that Governor Sherrill has signed executive orders to freeze utility rates and invest in battery storage, and that the Board of Public Utilities has since awarded contracts for 355 megawatts of storage and three gigawatts of solar, which he described as the largest solar award in the state's history.

"Local governments are significant land holders. Since siting is always a challenge, this is one way for us to be part of the solution and benefit from it."

Brian Pugh, Mayor of Croton-on-Hudson

7. OFFENSE, DEFENSE, AND THE PEOPLE OUTSIDE THE ROOM

Asked for one big idea each, the panel converged on integration and on audience. Pugh named microgrids and thermal networks as the village's untapped resource. Bhalla offered a sports analogy: the

batteries and solar and storage as mitigation is the offense. Adaptation is the defense. We need to recognize that warming will continue past 1.5 degrees Celsius, and that cities have to be built to absorb it. So, the big idea is getting the people working on each to talk to one another and find the places where the two combine. Ciechowska Polanco pointed to microgrids at community centers, first response hubs, and schools as the way resiliency becomes tangible to residents as a place of refuge.

Mayor Ramos-Herbert raised the hardest problem in the room, which is everyone who is not in it. D'Eufemia closed by noting the panel had barely touched microgrids or the packaging of resilient energy resources, pointing to California's duck curve, where heavy midday solar gives way to fossil generation at night for want of storage, and challenging the audience to pair solar, storage, geothermal, wind, and what comes next into an affordable all-of-the-above mix, on the grounds that energy now belongs with water, food, and housing as a basic necessity.

"It's great for the advocates. It's great for the already believers, but there's a whole lot of folks who don't get it. And if we don't get them on board, we're gonna sort of always be at a standstill."

Yadira Ramos-Herbert, Mayor of New Rochelle

KEY TAKEAWAYS

01	Write the plan before the crisis repeats. Hoboken's 2019 climate action plan named its two problems, coastal surge and chronic flooding, and turned Sandy into an implementation program: Rebuild by Design plus four resiliency parks built and a fifth in design.
02	Fund resilience out of growth. New Rochelle studied all six of its watersheds, then used revenue from 11,000 units of downtown development to commit \$10 million a year for ten years to stormwater mitigation.
03	Lead with what residents already feel. Neither mayor sold this as a climate agenda. It was rain anxiety, home values, health, and household finances in New Rochelle, and a budget shortfall in Croton-on-Hudson.
04	Clean energy can pay the bills. Croton's train station solar carport, stalled in planning documents for twenty years, returns over \$400,000 a year against a \$13 million tax levy and helps the village stay under the tax cap.
05	Municipal land is a siting answer. Local governments are among the largest landholders in their communities, and parking lots, train stations, and public works yards are where projects can actually go.
06	Pair the project with the problem. A battery project that rescues a struggling church, or that comes with a stormwater fix for a chronically flooding parcel, gets built. Naming the co-benefit changes the conversation and can move a community past a moratorium.
07	Plan offense and defense together. Mitigation and adaptation are usually staffed, funded, and discussed separately; the panel's shared ask was to look for the places where they combine, starting with microgrids at schools, community centers, and first response hubs.